

Healing Within Walls: A Safety Directors Approach to Treatment in Corrections

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CJ 4840: Correctional Treatment and Supervision

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May 4th, 2025

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When we imagine a world of justice and freedom, many may not think of the United States justice system. In turn, those many turn a complete blind eye to the correctional system. Within this system, however, is the foundation for justice and freedom. The only caveat is that inmates and their antisocial peers must give into the system in which they have been told by media and surrounding communities corrections, each with the responsibility to make sure the trust of those who trust none is acquired. All correctional workers can specialize in a form of correctional treatment that can vary from counseling, substance abuse treatment, security and safety in prisons, probation officers, etc. In and out of the prison system, the correctional system remains intact and working every day, all day with the goals to ensure and maintain security in the prison system, support rehabilitation, incapacitate anti-social groups from society and discourage criminal behavior in populations.

The following paper introduces a more niche side of corrections and analyzes how this career directly intersects with the broad goals of corrections. Throughout the paper, we will explore the career of the Iowa Department of Corrections Safety Director, Donald Stolley. With around a decade and a half of experience in rehabilitation and safety management positions, Stolley creates an aura of professionalism and unmatched knowledge of the career. Within this position, Stolley is responsible for “occupational safety and health” and “making sure we align the things we do with our requirements from outside agencies [OSHA, etc.]”.

With the goal to interview “correctional treatment” professionals, it is not often seen that a director of a section of corrections is interviewed. It took some time for Stolley to commit to an interview, even within said interview saying he was hesitant because of his background in many different “ABC’s of government” and committing to an interview with an unknown student might have been difficult. The rationale of continuing the process comes from an increasing interest while

contacting Stolley; *What does it mean to be a director of safety? How does this fit into the goals of the correctional system?* After the interview, it became apparent that Stolley's career deals directly and indirectly with the quality of treatment and rehabilitation for offenders, both of which are particularly important topics in the correctional field.

Within this paper we will cover Stolley's background and how they ultimately fit into their current role. We will examine the core aspects of their current career and how they tackle a unique challenge within their role every day they step into the office. Afterwards, we will continue to analyze and delve into the niche aspects of Stolley's emphasis on treatment and rehabilitation. He focuses on aspects of each area to properly complete the tasks involved in their role, keeping a level of professionalism and friendliness with other correctional staff and offenders he works directly with. Following, we highlight the challenges and successes that Stolley feels every day on the job. The question asked specifically; *What makes a day good? What makes a day bad?* He had answers for them, and it truly sheds light on what it means to be within the correctional system.

Background of Interviewee and their Role in the Corrections System

Stolley and I went over his background in detail before we started our conversation about the correctional system. He began school before quickly realizing he did not feel totally at home in college, and decided he needed something different; with that, he joined the Army. Stolley spent several years in the Army in a position in preventative medicine. He described it as "all about control of communicable diseases" and trying to follow guidelines from agencies that try and control the Army, but Stolly jokingly said "you know, the Army doesn't exactly follow OSHA guidelines". He was also involved in psychological operations within the Army, which consisted of mastering communication with foreign communities in which United States bases may be located. Within his time in the Army, he got to know the prison system as he was attached to a unit that was stationed at prisons in the Middle East. After the Army, Stolley returned to school

studying exercise physiology as a 27–28-year-old. He was later accepted to a physical therapy program, but he and his now wife were pregnant and “it was time for dad to earn some money”.

Moving to Maryland, Stolley worked for OSHA as an “industrial hygienist” involved in control of communicable diseases and exposures to things like asbestos or chemical encounters for employees on the job site. After several years at OSHA, he moved back home to Iowa and saw a posting for a Safety Officer position in Corville. He was not satisfied with that job, but it got him and his family more on their feet. Eventually, Stolley moved on to interview for the Safety Director position, stating that this was an interview he was “accidentally preparing for his whole life” and felt confident. Getting the job and within a few weeks in the position, Stolley knew that this was where he belonged. With over a year as Safety Director, he is just as passionate about it as he was in the beginning.

With his past in the Army, Stolley craved a sense of “this matters” in his career. He truly prides himself on helping others and creating a difference in the world, and the Safety Director career is perfect for such. He states that it is a “perfect marriage” and that going into work every day and knowing that you will do something that matters is exactly what keeps him going. As you may imagine, even with the perfect situation, being a Safety Director in a correctional system comes with no handbook. Stolley told me that it is like “putting the square peg in the round hole” and each day is a new peg. Both sides of corrections, employees and inmates, come directly to Stolley with complaints and suggestions for the correctional system. Each is their own unique situation, and there is not always a solution or a quick one; it is Stolley’s job to communicate and work through things to find solutions. He described himself as a “walk-in complaint box” but works hard every day to bring everyone’s ticket to a close to satisfy his employees and his inmates.

Key Themes and Intersections with Correctional Goals

Within the Safety Director position, there is an obvious emphasis on the safety and wellbeing of the inmates and employees within the correctional system. Not only is Stolley responsible for the prison system, but he is also in charge or indirectly in charge of the 23 residential treatment facilities (informally known as half-way houses). Throughout this intersection, the emphasis truly lies within treatment and rehabilitation as Stolley focuses mainly on those industries within the department of corrections. He works directly and indirectly with these two topics through things such as programs for reentry to society and employability, collaboration on job assignments, safety in the inmate work programs, working with treatment staff, ADA coordination and responding to incidents within the department. As alluded to, Stolley truly wants to see the best for all inmates (as well as employees) through his consistent emphasis on work programs and certification programs to set these men and women up for reentry success. He is a point for advocacy in which staff and incarcerated individuals can go to Stolley with questions and ideas for successful treatment and rehabilitation options. The dream in correctional systems is to make an environment in which there is a higher success rate in reentry than before, and Stolley's main drive is to achieve that goal.

Fitting the square peg into the round hole is truly a unique problem to have in a career, and this position is anything but standard. Stolley offers a unique insight into the behind-the-scenes operations within correctional systems. As the media portrays, there is a widespread belief that the treatment and rehabilitation system is truly corrupt and unsuccessful. But as Stolley and I were talking, it became clear to me that we have never seen the truly larger picture. Each employee within the correctional system I observed is dedicated and passionate about this job and what it means to society. There are just unfortunate situations that fail the incarcerated individuals whether that is within a prison, which cannot be completely controlled, or within a society that does not

accept ex-inmates with open arms. Stolley is dedicated to making sure each inmate he has worked with has an opportunity to be treated with the most equal treatment he can provide by making sure their every need is met and certifying that each person he helps treat walks away from prison whole and completely ready for the outside world.

Challenges and Rewards of the Role in Corrections

No career is all rainbows, however. I asked Stolley to provide some insight on challenges in the industry and he took his time formulating an answer. As most of his job is ensuring policies are followed, he said that some of the most challenging days are days when an incident occurs, and he must play a corporate role rather than a human one. An example of which he provided is when a situation such as a staff assault or inmate self-harm occurs. He is there for support, but his main job now is to ensure proper protocol. So, while his staff members may be enduring a tragic loss or traumatic moment, Stolley is asking things such as “did you wear your PPE?” He described it as incredibly difficult as he is a self-proclaimed people person and just “wants to give the person a hug while they look at me [Stolley] like ‘Did you just see what I went through?’ [After corporate questioning]”. The state of the matter is trying to balance regulations vs. realities, and that is the most challenging position to be in. Stolley wears his heart on his sleeve and truly feels all the failures within his job. As he described “the successes you expect out of yourself but the failures you will always hang onto”.

In a rewarding sense, Stolley told me a story of a very influential moment that truly is one of the reasons he gets up every day and continues doing the job he is proud of, even though the failures. At the Anamosa State Penitentiary, Iowa Prison Industries is a production mill where inmates work and develop skills that can translate to the outside world. With multiple job programs, one stuck out during this particular conversation, making street signs. Stolley described his visit to Iowa Prison Industries as a normal day taking complaints and having conversations,

but one conversation with an inmate in his late 50s to early 60s took his breath away. The inmate approached Stolley and asked if he was there to shut them down, to which Stolley said no and that he was just there to confirm everything was being used properly and the environment was safe. The inmate proceeded to ask what the verdict was and Stolley reassured that everything was just fine, to which the inmate responded “ok, but please don’t shut us down”. Stolley was taken aback, as the usual conversation is the complete opposite. It was at this moment Stolley brought up the complaint box joke. The inmate went on to tell him he has “accepted his time here” and assured he agrees with society's verdict to put the man in prison. However, making these street signs still gave the man an outlook on life and made him feel productive within his life and situation and helped the community more than he could as a “young man”.

Interactions such as this are what keeps Stolley working so hard to address and change the correctional system in which he works for the better. Even though both examples he provided me with are incredibly polarizing, Stolley said that there are unfortunate situations that come across, but his sources of satisfaction within the position are very strong that he continues to feed off them to provide the best possible reality within the regulations for his inmates and staff.

Conclusion

Donald Stolley’s career provides a lot of insight and connections to our course, CJ 4840: Correctional Treatment and Supervision. Through the course, we have studied many aspects of the correctional system from the very beginning to modern day aspects, including intense emphasis on many niche topics. Throughout this interview, Stolley was aware of what we have spoken of and tried his best to relate back, but his unique perspective not only related back but also expanded on the course material. Throughout his recollections of treatment and rehabilitation, it is very apparent that Stolley prides himself on a collaborative relationship between him and the incarcerated individuals he works with to promote an understanding and trustworthy community

(Van Vooris, pg. 23, 2022). Most of the methods Stolley described seemed to resonate within an indirect group therapy session such as working together or collaborating more than an individual one.

As Van Vooris states in our course reading, many group therapy methods instill many aspects in the inmates, but the most notable that Stolley attempts to instill is *hope, universality, and development of social skills* to set up inmates for success in the outside world when their time in the correctional system is over. But recidivism is a problem within all correctional systems and preventing such is a large undertaking; “for many policymakers, members of the general public, and correctional practitioners, reductions in recidivism represent the benchmark of effectiveness.” (Van Vooris, pg. 18, 2022) Society looks to correctional systems to prevent ex-criminals from engaging in criminal behavior again. It is clear in Stolley’s perspective that the correctional system does do their best in preventing, it is just up to the inmate to truly receive and use the information and resources given.

My time speaking to Stolley was truly a time well spent. His unique stories and examples really tied together the course in which I am taking. Everything Stolley had to say was interesting and fascinating. It was truly a great time and very connected to our learnings on treatment and rehabilitation. Stolley’s role as Safety Director is significant to the future of the correctional systems as we continue to try and influence and change the system to provide and reduce recidivism and being able to experience that role during the interview was a true pleasure and sincerely eye opening to the true meaning behind corrections. It goes without saying that as someone very inspired by helping people and continuing to try and make the world a better place, I would love to have the drive and determination of Donald Stolley.

References

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